Digital Sexual Violence, Revisited: A F/ISTs Approach to Deepfake Technology

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What are deepfakes?

Imagine waking up to find that a video of you, one you never recorded, has gone viral. Your face is unmistakable, yet the setting and actions depicted are a disturbing fabrication, showing you engaged in sexually explicit activities that never happened. Your phone buzzes relentlessly with notifications; people tag you and flood your inbox on X, demanding explanations. In a state of panic, you scramble to contact the platforms, desperately trying to have the videos removed. But even amid this turmoil, a sinking feeling tells you it's too late—the video has spread like wildfire, and even if the original is deleted, this video will linger in some dark corner of the internet. That is only a minuscule glimpse of what Megan Thee Stallion(born Megan Pete) must have felt in early June, 2024 when a pornographic deepfake of her videos, produced using Artificial Intelligence (AI) and using her likeness to appear as if she had consensually engaged in recording explicit acts, went viral on X. The following day, Megan Thee Stallion posted on X, "It's really sick how yall go out of the way to hurt me when you see me winning. Yall going too far, Fake ass shit. Just know today was your last day playing with me and I mean it" (@TinaSnow).

Megan Thee Stallion filed legal action against one of the main distributors of these deepfakes on X, Milagro Cooper. This legal action centered on a deepfake video where Megan Thee Stallion's likeness was superimposed onto explicit footage, which was then widely circulated on social media. The court documents highlight that while the creator of the deepfake is "unknown," Cooper's involvement was direct and deliberate, encouraging their large following to watch and further distribute this deepfake of Megan

Thee Stallion. Megan Thee Stallion's legal team emphasized that she neither authorized nor had any knowledge of the video's creation or distribution, asserting that "the lengths to which Defendant Cooper goes to harass Ms. Pete knows no bounds" (Pete 1). Through a close reading of the court document, it was made clear that Cooper had been a fan of Tory Lanez, a former partner of Pete's who had been arrested and convicted in December 2022 for assaulting her with a semiautomatic firearm, having a loaded, unregistered firearm in a vehicle and discharging a firearm with gross negligence after Megan Thee Stallion pressed charges. After Lanez's conviction, Cooper has consistently used their platform to harass, cyberstalk, and cyberbully Megan Thee Stallion.

The discourse on X makes it clear that the deepfakes bring on an onslaught of confusing reactions, with many doubting that the video was a deepfake, even though the original user had released the deepfake of Megan Thee Stallion alongside the original video they used to create it. The phenomena of deepfake AI content in general, and the case of celebrity deepfakes in particular, bring up a variety of concerns, including authorship and privacy, consent, digital sexual violence, and cyberbullying. This paper focuses on how deepfakes extend discourses of misogyny and sexual violence in digital spaces through digital technology and the internet's inherent structure of exposure, exploitation, and cyclical violence (Chun 2004, 2016). The internet facilitates spaces of bullying, misogyny, and sexual violence while blaming internet users for existing on digital platforms (Chun 2016). As a result, users feel entitled to others' bodies and feel indifferent when those bodies are manipulated for further exposure.

"Deepfake," a term originally coined in 2017 by a Reddit user named "deepfake", refers to media content created by individuals using Artificial Intelligence (AI). This

technology is used to manipulate or replace a person's likeness or voice in media content, usually a video, for entertainment purposes. In technical terms, deepfakes entail a "manipulation of existing media (image, video, or audio) or the generation of new (synthetic) media using deep learning-based approaches" like complex neural networks (machine learning) (Altuncu et al. 1). The Reddit user created a unique algorithm that used autoencoders, a combination of encoders and decoder to perform facial swaps amongst source media and target media. The encoder compresses the input image into a lower-dimensional latent representation, and the decoder reconstructs the image from this latent representation and in doing so learns the facial expression and movement of the images.

In the case of this algorithm, two autoencoders are trained: one on the source face, in the context of our case study, this would be the face of Megan Thee Stallion, and another on the target face, the explicit video the creator used to generate the deepfake. When trained, the algorithm passes the source face through the shared encoder to obtain the lower-dimensional representation and then feeds this into the target decoder, producing source facial features combined with target expressions and movements. This algorithm was later distributed and shared on GitHub, providing wide access to the code and enabling the public to use it with relative ease. Over time, applications like FakeApp simplified the process of creating deepfakes by offering a user-friendly interface, which allowed users to create deepfakes without needing a deep understanding of the underlying technology (while feeding the algorithms with user data to improve their capacities). The integral part of machine learning algorithms is that it is cyclical by nature. Once a machine learning model is deployed, it is not uncommon for creators to then use the

inputs from new users to further train their model, allowing the algorithm to become more realistic. Often, the data used to train a machine learning algorithm determines how good that algorithm is, so the more data, the better the algorithm.

The first viral deepfake came in 2018 when Jordan Peele curated a video where former President Barack Obama appeared to say, "Donald Trump is a total and complete dipshit" ("You Won't Believe What Obama Says In This Video! 😉"). This video was intended as a public service announcement to highlight the dangers of deepfakes, especially regarding misinformation, and to demonstrate how realistic these AI-altered videos could be. In this video, Jordan Peele acted as a stand-in, presenting himself as Barack Obama, and with the use of deepfake technology, superimposed the former president's face (and voice) onto his own. Now we see deepfakes and synthetic media, media created through the use of artificial intelligence, almost everywhere, from Coca-Cola Christmas commercials to Elon Musk retweeting a deepfake of Democratic candidate Kamala Harris claiming that she was the "ultimate diversity hire" (Alsharif et al.). So, despite Jordan Peele's attempt to shine a light on the dangers of this ever-evolving technology, it is evident that users have simply fixated on how much this technology can do.

The allure with deepfakes has expanded significantly since 2018, deepfakes can now be found circulating abundantly on social media platforms. TikTok has been a prime example of this, accounts like @deeptomcriuse have accumulated 3.6 million followers by simply creating deepfake videos impersonating Tom Cruise. In addition to that, there has been a rise of deepfake accounts surrounding people presenting as celebrities, notably @unreal_robert, with Robert Pattinson, and @unreal_keanu, with Keanu Reeves. The

videos consist mostly of these celebrities doing TikTok trends, which seems harmless because it's made very clear from the name of these accounts that it is not the celebrity or artist. These Tiktok accounts of male celebrities have a humorous intent but that completely changes when we see users begin to create deepfakes of women. Often these deepfakes tend to be sexually explicite in nature and exposes these women to an onslaught of hateful comments. We see this in the case of Megan Thee Stallion's leaked deepfakes where her image was placed on top of a pornographic video to make it seem as if she was participating in it herself. So the concern is that the entertainment and humour of all this new found technology may simply be masking the realities of it. Technology has always been pervasive but what does it mean now that people can create synthetic media of you doing or saying something that you would never do or say? What are the implications of having your image used to create content that completely misrepresents your character, actions, or behaviors? What does it mean that this possibility now feels like the price to pay for inhabiting digital space? And how does this further intensify existing concerns regarding online misogyny?

In order to think about these questions, we must acknowledge the inherent nature of new media. New media has always been confusing due to how it creates an illusion of privacy and intimacy that doesn't really exist. To understand the affordances of deepfake technology, we must first come to an understanding of the cultural impact of new media.

The lighthearted nature of its initial applications is starkly contrasted by its darker side. An analysis of this requires us first to acknowledge the preexisting concerns regarding privacy, exposure, and the promiscuous nature of the internet. Media scholar Wendy Chun studies the gendered and racialized constructions of data analysis and

algorithmic/new media. Her analysis discovers the inherent nature of these systems, which are programmed as leaking mechanisms that expose users. She believes that new media creates environments with conditions that encourage people to share information they might not normally disclose. Let's take the example of a user on X who decides to have their post protected. The understanding of enabling this setting on your account is that only those who follow you may have access to your posts, and when someone wants to follow you, a request is sent that you must approve. In a sense, these protected posts are similar to putting up a note on your bedroom door where the only people who can see this note are people who you have let into your home. The issue is that the other users who have access to your post have no obligation to keep this post private; they have the freedom to take screenshots and share this content that you believe you have 'protected'. The distribution of this screenshot is what Chun refers to as the "leaking" quality of digital media. Chun believes that new media is beyond just that; she claims that "new media are not simply about leaks: they are leaks" (4).

New media goes beyond simply creating a false sense of security where people feel they can post and say anything, but further erode the very distinction between what is meant to be private and public, making exposure an inherent feature rather than an accidental flaw. Chun uses the example of 'friend' on the social network Friendster. She states that by depending on "public exhibition of private relationships in order to allow private interactions," Friendster confuses the boundaries between public and private (Chun 6). We can go back to the example of X private posts to further explain this confusion. As an X user, you might receive requests from coworkers or even your boss to follow you on X, meaning they would now have access to your private posts. The intent

of your coworkers or boss may simply be to get to know you better, but their presence in your digital space fundamentally changes what you decide to post and how you navigate this space. Though the space is private, because you have opted for it to be, it is still public because your coworkers and boss now have access to it. This continuous state of leaking turns users into both consumers and producers of surveillance, as their personal information, behaviors, and interactions become part of a broader network of visibility and data circulation. Chun states, "From social media's privatization of surveillance to its redefinition of friends, new media compromise the boundary between revolutionary and conventional, public and private" (4). As a result, these wireless networks merge the personal and the public into "the networked," which refers to the interconnected digital environment where personal data and activities are constantly transmitted, shared, and potentially monitored.

This compromise of boundaries and leakiness leads to what Chun calls the promiscuous mode of technology. She argues that when data is transmitted through wireless network cards, these cards "download and read in all packets (data) it can then erase those not directly addressed to it," but if it is running in promiscuous mode, it sends these packets to its central processing unit (Chun 5). This promiscuity means that every user has probably downloaded all sorts of illegal materials, and their network card is technically dirty, but without this process, there would be no network or internet, and we could only describe our machines as promiscuous if we view them as personal. Regardless of whether a machine is a part of a network or not, it will still leak. Chun explains that new media stores information by making it so that "for something to remain, it must not remain; it must be regenerated" (5). In other words, digital

information cannot be preserved if the information remains unchanged; for it to remain legible, this data must be either shared and distributed or altered. Chun suggests that digital information must continuously change to remain accessible. This is due to constantly changing and mechanically upgrading software. This introduces Chun's paradox, which claims that "what does not change will not endure, yet change–progress (endless upgrades) – ensures that what endures will fade" (5). This simply translates to "once it's there, it is there to stay," not because of the inherent nature of technology, but due to the extensive human-techno-political system that copies to save. This concept of copying to save explains the leaky nature of technology and human interaction because it tells us that even in the case where the source of an image or video decides to take it down, this image/video has probably been backed up in their CPU, copied by another user and hence additionally backed up in that users CPU indicating that this image/video will never truly be deleted.

Ruha Benjamin introduces the concept of coproduction of technology and the human shaping social imaginaries and norms. She emphasizes that an analysis that centers the role of technology in co-production is necessary due to how technology "aids and abets" racial, gender, and class injustice (2). As per Benjamin's claims, the evolution of technology, and in the case of this particular argument, the evolution of deepfake technology, requires us to rethink how we view and interact with technology. Specifically in this current moment where the creation of synthetic media has become so normalized, and through the celebration of TikTok accounts like @deeptomcriuse, there is a need to evaluate how this may allow for misogynists to further exploit and dehumanize women. Benjamin states we need to rethink the relationship between technology and society and

claims that a “more expansive tool kit is necessary, one that bridges science and technology studies and critical race studies” to discuss not only how society is impacted by technology but how social norms make some technology appear inevitable and others impossible (4). Benjamin’s inter-implication of technology and society in coproduction is what Chun refers to as the human-techno-politics of new media (4). Benjamin uses the example of Simone Browne in her book *Dark Matters*, where Browne examines how surveillance technologies co-produce notions of Blackness. Browne argues in this piece that current technologies of surveillance, like biometric tracking and facial recognition, which often misclassify or confuse one black body for another, simply reinforce racial hierarchies and systemic inequalities. Overall, this makes clear that technology does not live in a vacuum and rather reproduces human biases under the guise of technological objectivity.

With this framework in mind, Chun would argue that the human-techno-politics of technology, or coproduction, imply that the technology will inevitably reproduce human biases. As a result, to understand the dangers of this new technology, we must explore the patriarchal and racist inheritance of this system and how new media platforms situate themselves as a means to exploit this inherent nature. In her most recent book, *Discriminating Data: Correlation, Neighborhoods and the New Politics of Recognition* (2021), Chun also discusses how the recommendations on social media feeds work. She makes it clear that this is not solely based on the individual's history alone but rather by “segregating users into ‘neighborhoods’ or petri dishes based on their slightly odd or deviant—that is, ‘authentic’—likes or dislikes” (41). This is presumably how the X algorithm also works: clustering people into groups of like-minded individuals to create

recommendations for posts that make the most sense with their demographic. This clustering algorithm is verified as correct by their ability to predict the past. Chun highlights this when discussing Youyou, Kosinski and Stillwell's use of cross-validation in their creation of a model that would estimate a range of Facebook users characteristics. She claims that in the building of their linear regression model, Youyou and colleagues used "90 percent of their data as training to build a linear regression model for predicting personality type, and then tested it against the remaining 10 percent for verification" (Chun, 47). So "if the captured and curated past is racist and sexist, these algorithms and models will only be verified as correct if they make sexist and racist predictions" (Chun, 47). This is a regular practice amongst supervised learning models in machine learning because the label, the target that we want the model to output, is known.

Machine learning algorithms that create racial and gendered clusters make online environments more prone to repeating large-group social behavior. In this project's case in particular, an environment that could bash and shame Megan Thee Stallion about deepfakes that she didn't know existed. In other words, it created a space where anonymity and popular perception fuel misogynistic commentary. For unsupervised learning models, like clustering used in social networks, there are no labels, but the notion of making predictions from the past is very similar because it is centered on the model's generalizability. Chun emphasizes, "by using data analytics, individual differences and similarities are actively sought, shaped and instrumentalized in order to capture and shape social clusters"(49). She makes it evident that social networks use this to provoke control techniques to "manage, prune and predict"(49). This method makes old methods of discrimination and control seem harmless because the technology is

perceived as unbiased, which it is not. The underlying assumption of these models is that "by knowing as few as one like, they could determine a user's related 'intimate' traits" (Chun, 45). An example she used was that given how highly correlated liking the Wu-Tang Clan band was to heterosexual males, the algorithm would imply that a user's sexual orientation is based on this specific feature. In many ways, these clustering algorithms view users as data points, where each plane is a characteristic of the user, and group them based on their proximity to each other in this overall space. The prime concern here is that using race, gender, class, etc. as primary features is just creating racially segregated spaces on the internet.

The creation of clusters and further exploitation of users' data is only possible due to the digital platforms' consent framework, which exonerates these platforms from any responsibility in protecting users' data and allows them to exploit users' data bodies. Joana Varon and Paz Peña reference Daniel Solove's concept of "privacy self-management" to refer to policymakers' aim to equip individuals with certain rights, enabling them to make informed choices about how their data is used. Varon and Peña argue that this model frames consent as an individual responsibility, assuming that people are fully autonomous, free, and rational actors capable of giving meaningful consent. perspective, they note, ignores the constraints many face due to unequal power dynamics: "This is an individual framing of consent, based on the assumption that we are all autonomous, free, and rational individuals with the capacity to consent, disregarding our possibility of doing so due to unequal power dynamics" (Varon & Peña, 9). This framing appeals to digital platforms, as it facilitates "notice and consent" practices that treat personal information as part of the price of online participation. For example X's privacy

policy often uses vague and unclear phrases like “we may share or disclose your information with third parties” without making it clear who the ‘third parties’ are. Additionally it spans multiple pages with several links to sub policies which would require users to spend long periods of time reading and clicking in order to get a clear picture of how their data is collected, shared or sold. This encourages the notion of tacit consent, which implies that users inhabiting a space are inherently consenting to all the rules and regulations of this space without acknowledging how these social media platforms use languages and long lists of requirements that are sometimes difficult to understand and cumbersome to read. These platforms' consent framework is reflected in their user’s response to a clear violation of other’s consent. We see this in the response to Megan Thee Stallion’s deepfakes on X, where users make it clear that they feel that her digital presence gives them the allowance to have access to her body. This mindset absolves platforms from the responsibility of protecting user data in a similar way that this allows for users to feel absolved of any guilt from viewing and distributing this pornographic content.

The inherent nature of technology allows it to exploit users and sell their data, but frames it in a way that relieves them of any responsibility. As this technology evolves and grows, the danger associated with technology further exacerbates the misogyny that lingers within it. Sexually explicit deepfakes that are created and distributed without consent become a clear form of digitally facilitated gender-based violence, which requires us to revisit sexual violence and how it manifests itself.

According to Kat Tenbarge's, “96% of deepfakes are sexually explicit and feature women who didn’t consent to the creation of the content,” with websites like

Mr.DeepFake and Fantopia being the main distribution sites for monetized celebrity deepfakes(Tenbarge, 2023). According to this article, many of the creators for both sites have set up Discord accounts where they both discuss the AI technology behind creating the deepfakes while simultaneously recruiting more AI developers to create more of this content. A huge aspect of this pornographic deepfake is its realism. When the deepfakes of Megan Thee Stallion circulated on X, there were many questioning whether or not they were actually deepfakes or if Megan Thee Stallion had actually participated in the creation of this sexually explicit content and was now just ashamed of her participation. Though the original person who posted her deepfake had done so alongside the original pornographic video they had used to create the deepfake, after the original post was deleted, many doubted the legitimacy of Megan Thee Stallion's deepfake claim. Though celebrities are currently the focus of this deepfake economy, regular people are also targeted. In 2020 Noelle Martin presents a TedTalk where she recounts her own encounter with digitally facilitated gender based violence mediated through deepfake. She recounts that in 2016 she had a moment of curiosity where she wanted to see what a reverse image search of herself would produce (Martin, 2020). She was then confronted with dozens of images of herself stolen from her social media and manufactured, edited, and doctored to be then uploaded on dozens of porn websites. The concerns with deepfake technology is its current rampant use in the porn economy and the curation of sexually explicit non consensual content of women.

Digital sexual violence refers to the use of digital technologies to explicitly and sexually harass, exploit, or violate individuals without their consent. Traditionally, this phenomenon occurs in the form of distributing sexually explicit content of someone

without their consent. The introduction of deepfake technology regurgitates this existing phenomena by artificially producing this form of content by using people's likeness and other (usually anonymous) people's bodies. The victim of deep fake sexual violence does not even have to engage in recording intimacy or other forms of digital intimacy for their likeness to be used. The user can suffer exposure without ever knowing where the content comes from. This requires us to approach these leaks using a new methodology so that we can concretely understand the harm technology is proliferating.

Methodology

Critical Technocultural Discourse Analysis (CTDA), coined by media scholar André Brock, refers to the "multimodal analytic technique for the investigation of Internet and digital phenomena, artifacts and culture" (1). It combines the analysis of information technology material and virtual design with a cultural exploration into the production of meaning through information technology practices and the responses of information technology users, bringing in critical race theory, feminism, and other critical theory discourses. CTDA is designed to be open to any critical theoretical framework. It requires users to go beyond simply analyzing the digital artifact and the responses to that artifact, and also analyze the digital environment that has allowed that digital artifact to exist and permeate through posts, likes, and reposts. This differs from traditional content analysis because it allows for a broader more critical approach on the technological and cultural impact of the circulating artifact.

Blending the framework of co production and techno-politics of the social with CTDA, I plan to analyze how deepfakes have been used as a mechanism to further

exacerbate racial and gender hierarchies in digital space. More specifically, using CTDA as a means to explore the case study of Megan Thee Stallions' leaked deepfakes provides a more nuanced approach to our current understanding of sexual violence in digital spaces, exploring how entitlement, anonymity, and the existing cycle of violence present in digital spaces are further exacerbated by the introduction of new AI technology like deepfakes. Megan Thee Stallion, as Black female rap artist who raps about female sexuality and female sexual liberation, has continuously been targeted by online misogynists. The pervasiveness of sexual conservatism in the industry has subjected her to constant scrutiny. CTDA will allow me to come to the conclusion that the circulating of Megan Thee Stallions deepfake was not solely intended to 'expose' her but function as a mediated act of sexual violence, one that weaponizes emerging technology to reaffirm patriarchal power and control over women's bodies.

A Computer science framework will allow me to look at how the X algorithm works to create what Chun describes as the new politics of recognition. This algorithm clusters groups and creates a digital environment that allows users with specific interests to interact only with those interests. This process of clustering is executed using machine learning models, which Chun believes perpetuates pre-existing racist, sexist, and classist ideals. In the analysis of this clustering algorithm, it will be necessary to introduce race in the study of Megan Thee Stallion's deepfake media. The clustering algorithm provides us with an understanding of how specific groups of people were exposed to this deepfake content and articles addressing this digital artifact, but it does not tell us what has led to the cycle of violence present in the comment section of these articles. A feminist media studies framework on the news outlets reporting her deepfakes and how they create

clusters of misogynists in the comment section will give us an understanding of how this technology heightens existing misogynistic ideals on the internet. Lastly, an intersectional feminist framework allows us to put this all together, look beyond the media and technology, and attribute these responses to the human-techno-politics present on social media platforms. This requires us to look at technology differently. Ruha Benjamin claims that we must look at technology as "not just a bystander that happened to be at the scene of the crime; it aids and abets" racial, gender, and class injustice (2). CTDA allows me to explore the realities of evolving technology in an interdisciplinary way, creating a clearer picture of how deepfakes complicate sexual violence in digital spaces.

Despite the amount of information available regarding deepfakes and Megan Thee Stallion on the internet, it has been surprisingly difficult to find conversations surrounding this incident. The original deepfake was taken down from X. The reposts of the video have also been scraped from X, making it difficult to identify the responses to the original video, whether or not they differ from those of people who simply heard the news from a different news outlet. The hardest part about analyzing a digital artifact on a social media platform is that the next day, any proof of that artifact can be scraped, and though this information may still exist in someone's CPU, it is no longer easily accessible to me. This is necessary to acknowledge as I analyze the comments and reactions to the reports of *My Mixtapez* and *Daily Loud* regarding the Megan Thee Stallion deepfake. Additionally, bringing to light the absence of empathy in the comment section tells us something about the cultural perception of non-consensual deepfake creation and distribution.

Technology facilitated gender-based violence

The use of deepfakes to create non consensual sexually explicit content has created a brand new form of technology-facilitated gender-based violence. Before the introduction of this new technology, fears of getting leaked were based primarily on having previously participated in recording intimacy or other forms of digital intimacy, or badly photoshopped images of oneself on a body with a slightly off complexion—images that could easily be distinguished as fake. Now, these fears have significantly expanded as technology has become more sophisticated and able to create hyper-realistic, sexually explicit content by just using your profile picture. It feels extremely invasive and scary that the cost of existing in the digital space is the threat of mass exposure and outing with images that you didn't even know existed. But as per Chun, Benjamin, Varon, and Peña, it is clear that the internet has always been an exposing mechanism that functions off its ability to heighten and contain real-world issues into a 6-inch brick that you carry around in your back pocket. Through the analysis of the response to the mass distribution of Megan Thee Stallion's deepfake video on X, I will continue to explore how deepfake technology intensifies/amplifies the internet's exposing nature. Through the perceived anonymity of the internet, deepfake technology amplifies users' sense of entitlement, creating illusions of intimacy through parasocial relationships and perpetuating the cycle of violence that permeates online.

Entitlement and Anonymity

What is clear through the analysis of Megan Thee Stallion's deepfakes is that patriarchal and misogynistic behaviors are being co-produced with technology. In analyzing the reactions to her deepfakes, we see a manifestation of what Sarah

Banet-Weiser refers to as “popular misogyny,” which she defines as “the instrumentalization of women as objects, where women are a means to an end: a systematic devaluing and dehumanizing of women” (2). This can be seen in comments like “this photo look like the you getting dicked down down in the video”(@jusomagi) and “Where the video @ with her eating Nikki-box”(@kirklan_gtyuth) both blatantly objectify Megan Thee Stallion, reducing her to a source of sexual gratification. The coproduction of misogyny is exacerbated by the presumed anonymous nature of the internet. Though Chun makes it clear that users are constantly being tracked and surveilled, this presumed anonymity brings back the blurred boundaries between the public and private. There is privacy for the user because they are writing from the ‘private’ with the phone, perhaps choosing not to reveal their identity, but public because social networks still have all your data that could point to who you are. One of the controversial features of internet use is the ability to act anonymously, which provides additional complexities to holding the people on the internet accountable. According to the X help center, “X allows the use of pseudonymous accounts, meaning an account’s profile is not required to use the name or image of the account owner” (X Help Center). This creates the illusion of anonymity despite what we learned earlier about the exposing nature of the internet. We see this as users under pseudonyms like @ct_daee posted, “Bitch fuck ya rat ass free Troy” (X).

This illusion of anonymity in juxtaposition with Chun’s claims that new media blurs the boundaries between the public and the private makes it unsurprising that users begin to say or do things they normally wouldn’t. While Chun argues that digital media blurs the boundaries between public and private, I contend that what’s actually happening

is that the perceived anonymity of platforms like X leads users to feel less compelled to keep certain thoughts private. We know that there are misogynistic people in this world, but what we see on the internet is people who thrive off the objectification of women, who then feel like they can express these views without any repercussions, making their hatred and expression of that hatred more intense. Per Banet-Weiser's explanation, one of the most dangerous aspects of popular misogyny is that it is seen as the norm. She claims that because women's bodies are usually objectified and sexualized, in the coproduction of misogyny in digital spaces they become hypervisible, so when they speak out, act out, or simply exist in a way that deviates from the norm, they are hypercriticised and ultimately shunned and shamed. In contrast, when men express their desires, because it is perceived as the norm, "the result is that popular misogyny lives in widespread sentiments that 'boys will be boys' when they commit sexual violence" (Banet-Weiser, 32). Though this is not specifically seen or manifested in the case of Megan Thee Stallion, as no one explicitly pardons the violent response to her deepfakes being leaked, the lack of condemnation (or the very little condemnation) proves Banet-Weiser's point that misogyny is the norm in digital space.

What we do see through the comment section of news outlets reporting on the leaked deepfakes, namely *My Mixtapez* and *Daily Loud*, is that Megan Thee Stallion's deviation from the norm, the norm being sexual conservatism—a deviation that she didn't even partake in—makes her the target of popular misogyny. Although in this particular instance she has not consented to a deepfake, her status as a celebrity is often interpreted as a closeness to this deviation. Megan Thee Stallion deviates from the popular misogynist norm by rapping about female sexuality making her body more

visible through her lyrics. Megan Thee Stallion's music videos often feature her dancing seductively and dressed with very little clothing. Her brand is her sexuality and her sexual liberty and as the norm for popular misogynists is sexual conservatism they view her as though she is doing something culpable. Her deviation is made even more visible by her celebrity status which heightens her visibility. As previously mentioned, Megan Thee Stallion's status as a female rapper is one of her first of many offenses to popular misogyny. To return to Banet-Weiser, popular misogyny takes a range of forms including "increase in death and rape threats expressed on social media platforms towards women … who enter into previously male-dominated professions" (33). This is evident as mentioned by Hazel Cills, rap is a male-dominated industry, according to her "in a 2017 survey of 15 hip-hop labels, Pitchfork writer Sheldon Pearce found that none of the rosters were more than 36% women artists, and none had signed more than two female rappers."(Cills, 2018). In addition to this offense, the subjects of her raps are seen to be her second offense and expressing her sexuality in this manner as a public figure is her last. Users claim, "How can you sexualize yourself this much and still play victim rn?" (@purplepillpodtx). Here, it is clear that the user seems to imply that by making music and presenting herself in a way that deviates their norm, the norm that is upheld by popular misogyny, Megan Thee Stallion has given up the right to her likeness. As previously mentioned, Megan Thee Stallion's image, which is based to a degree on the hypervisibility of her body, makes users respond to her deepfakes' with a lack of empathy because, again, they feel that through her revealing her body and through her celebrity status, she no longer has the right to complain. Another user claims "People do anything and everything to be rich and famous. Then when they achieve it, and shit happens to

them because they rich and famous, they complain 🙄😭🤦🏾‍♀️" (@RockStarRocc). This makes it clear that not only her deviation from the norm but also her celebrity status make some users feel like the circulation and creation of this deepfake content can be blamed solely on her and her actions.

The technical side of this co-production enables and exacerbates entitled misogynist behavior online because it congregates these misogynistic people into spaces with others like them creating spaces where they no longer feel they need to regulate their thoughts. X's algorithm is based on the clustering machine learning model similar to the ones described above, where correlations in data points are generalized as a means of recommending posts to users. Through correlations of being a misogynist and viewing posts by these specific news outlets, the clustering algorithm facilitates the congregating of these popular misogynists in the comment section as they become more likely to view this content. In the case of Megan Thee Stallion's deepfakes, *My Mixtapez*, branding itself as "the ultimate destination for all things hip-hop and rap," and *Daily Loud*, covering "the latest hip-hop news," were both the main distribution channels around Megan Thee Stallion's deepfakes. Though there were a few tweets regarding Megan Thee Stallion's deepfakes, the highest saturation of these comments stemmed from posts from these two news sources. We see the congregation of popular misogynists in the response to news outlets like the *Daily Loud* where their post about Megan Thee Stallions deepfake amongst the 15 previewed response only 3 of them were empathetic while 6 contained misogynistic undertones and blamed Megan Thee Stallion for this leaked content.These spaces that present themselves simply as platforms for sharing and distributing hip-hop content become spaces where algorithmically clustered users express

misogynistic attitudes that revolve around entitlement to and ownership of women's bodies. The issue is not hip-hop culture itself but rather the way the X algorithm, as Chun describes, "capture[s] and shape[s] social clusters" (49) by linking individuals based on perceived similarities. Both news outlets on X have consistently produced and published media content primarily surrounding men in the hip-hop and rap community. Though one could argue that this maybe a result of the rap industry being particularly male dominated but this argument is mute when you realize that the articles they do release about women are primarily about these women's deviation from the norm ie when they are presenting themselves as sexual beings or when the or upholding the norm ie these women's romantic relationships and their children. For example, out of the *Daily Loud* 18 consecutive tweets on X, only 2 that refer to women by name. One of them was in reference to whether or not Cardi B has the best Brazilian butt lift (BBL) . In this post aptly titled "Does Cardi B have the best BBL right now?? 👀🤔" the *Daily Loud* objectifies Cardi B, a successful female rapper, reducing her to nothing more than her body but more specifically her surgical enhancements. The use of the emojis 👀 and 🤔introduces a voyeurist aspect to it encouraging users to look and judge.The other post was centered around who Woah Vicki is currently dating titled "Woah Vicky just dropped a selfie with Charleston White 📸🤣." Though the title doesn't seem overtly misogynistic it does have misogynistic undertones. The emoji's that accompany the title suggests ridicule and mockery of Woah Vicky which reflects a pattern of belittling women for existing or expressing themselves online. It is important to acknowledge that these news outlets know what they are doing. They have a deep understanding of social platforms and create these headings to for a lack of better word go viral. The way they

choose to phrase and caption these post are indicative of the audience they aim to attract.This highlights what Banet-Weiser says about popular misogyny culture, where she says “media representation of misogyny is framed in such a way, with a focus on anomalous individuals”(34). Though she talks about this in regards to men, this notion can be translated to what women these media outlets decide to post about and how they decide to do so. So the clustering of these misogynists in the comment section of Megan Thee Stallions deepfake posts is not just due to the nature of these accounts as hip-hop news outlets but rather their nature as nodes in the overall popular misogynist network and when users are enveloped by comments victim blaming and further objectifying Megan Thee Stallion they no longer feel obligated to filter their own misogynistic thoughts.

The entitlement express in these comment is not simply a reflection of individual prejudice, it is a product of the digital infrastructure itself. The cluster algorithm on platforms like X plays a pivotal role in that it creates an echo chamber of popular misogynists. Creating digital spaces where misogynistic in not only normalized but it is encouraged through visibility. As previously mentioned many posts surrounding Megan Thee Stallion’s deepfake have been scraped including the original post itself. The question of why comments objectifying and belittling Megan Thee Stallion still linger in these comment section emphasizes its normalcy. Users are not merely hiding behind pseudonyms like “@momajor_” or “@bolt393272” but they are actively participating in a carefully curated feedback loop that rewards dehumanizing content. For example comments like “She doin erthing BUT rapping” (@ladeejheay) and “Then all of a sudden she dropping an Album? #Marketing” (@XNivri1985) confidently speculates on Megan

Thee Stallion's intentions, dismissing her actions as attention-seeking or opportunistic without any need for evidence or empathy. Others like "Professional victim" (@KuuChief) and "she is just looking for attention! we cover this already" (@Marcuscox5) frames her response to violation as disingenuous or manipulative revealing a sense of entitlement to her silence. These are not critiques grounded in critical reflection, they are expressions of cultural entitlement shaped by gendered expectations and emboldened by anonymity.

The anonymity of the internet makes people feel even more entitled to invade others' space and to say things about people they don't even know. Banet-Weiser claims that popular misogyny is reactive, a reaction to deviations from the norm. What I would add is that the anonymous nature of the internet inflates the entitlement manifested through popular misogyny due to the illusion that they won't be held responsible. This aspect of social networks creates an environment where people feel emboldened not only to share deepfakes but also to post vile comments, such as one user who, under a post condemning those who circulated Megan Thee Stallion's deepfake, remarked, "I jerk off to it every day" (@JustineWest65911). The structure of these platforms does not simply reflect popular misogyny—it actively facilitates and magnifies it, making digital spaces breeding grounds for violence cloaked as entertainment or commentary.

Parasocial Relationships

The existing sense of entitlement that is amplified by anonymity may be further reinforced by the illusion of intimacy created by parasocial relationships. Parasocial relationships, as defined by John Mark Cuellar, "are one-way relationships between

individuals and characters from various forms of media" (276). In these relationships users' engagement with the media makes them feel like they are in a real relationship with the person or persona on the other end of the screen (Horton & Wohl). Celebrities like Megan Thee Stallion often curate this relationship with their audience, which leads to an illusion of intimacy that I would say further amplifies their audience's sense of entitlement. We see this in the comments reacting to her deepfake, where this user feels they can pass judgment as if they are close friends of Megan Thee Stallion. The user states, "I've never seen Meg say anything positive the past few years… gotta roll with the punches on her stage" (@Chancey_L), reflecting the belief that Megan Thee Stallion owes her audience emotional positivity and resilience even as she is being publicly violated. An example of this illusion of intimacy is enabled through X's live streams. The persona, celebrity, or influencer goes live. They casually place their phones on their kitchen counter, nightstand, or walk-in closet and speak to their fans in a way that feels like a FaceTime call. Again, this new media blurs the lines between the public and the private while still providing that cloak of anonymity. Horton and Wohl state, "in due time, the devotee—the 'fan'—comes to believe that he knows the persona more intimately and profoundly than others do" (3). This sense of knowing better makes users feel their opinion is equally as important or even more important than Megan Thee Stallion. One user dismisses and undermines Megan Thee Stallion's emotional response and states "Boo hoo poor little Megan" (@pinkie_bunniiee). This false closeness in the comments above manifest in a form of increased entitlement, or demanding more of the persona from the audience.

The audience's feelings that make them believe they know the persona more than others may result in unrealistic expectations and perceived understanding of the persona's actions. This results in disbelief of deepfakes (if the persona is doing something that people come to expect from them) and an erasure of consent as it pertains to the actions of the deepfake. It is not uncommon for fans to demand reactions from celebrities or influencers with whom they believe they have a certain relationship. We see it consistently when fans crowd around celebrities' comment sections or DMs to get noticed and prompt a reaction from these celebrity personas. In Megan Thee Stallion's case, the disbelief surrounding the circulation of her deepfakes did not stem solely from a defense of her image but rather from a belief that the content aligned too well with her public persona. For many, the hypersexualized nature of the deepfakes seemed plausible within the framework of her brand, one rooted in sexual empowerment and performance. For instance, one user speculated in regards to the circulating deepfake that “it is probably real…” (@PatriotCards444). While others feel like this user who feigns outrage, “Who got the link?” (@Aeroprostate), highlighting how quick people go from outrage to consumption of the violation simply because they feel her sexual persona invites it. But popular misogyny and the overall exposing nature of the internet show us that the commodification and hyper visibility of women’s bodies allows for these women to be completely stripped of their agency. Megan Thee Stallion’s sexual agency, which is a central and empowering aspect of her artistry, is distorted through the creation and circulation of deepfakes. These fabrications weaponize her expressions of empowerment, twisting them into justifications for non-consensual exploitation. In doing so, the line between consensual performance and involuntary violation is deliberately blurred. The

result is not simply an attack on her image, but an erasure of her consent altogether, where the visibility of her sexuality is misused to validate acts of digital violence against her.

Cycle of violence

The creation and distribution of pornographic deepfake content without consent is a form of technologically facilitated sexual violence, one that displaces bodily autonomy and reasserts patriarchal control through digital means. Chun defines this violent act of outing and exposure as the epistemology of outing "a mode of knowledge production that focuses on the exposure of 'secrets,' open or not" (150). The act of creating these deepfakes is not simply about misrepresentation, but it creates an epistemic violence: it exposes the subject in a way that reduces them to a spectacle, where the spectacle isn't simply the sexual act but who is partaking in it. Chun further explains that the goal of outing is shame, "shame for being in the closet, shame for what one does in the closet" (150). The intent of the exposure is to generate mass shaming of those who are being exposed. Additionally, this epistemology is not about truth but power, it frames visibility as a form of domination where the goal is not just to reveal but to control, shame, and discipline. In Megan Thee Stallion's case, though her brand is centered around her sexuality and choosing to express it as she pleases, there is some shock and surprise in seeing her engage in something so explicit, where nothing is hidden and she is fully exposed. As a response, users have opted to shame her for this circulating video, perfectly exemplifying how outing and shame can be seen in the circulation of her sexually explicit deepfakes. There is a stark difference between choosing to express sexuality and being non-consensually rendered hyper-visible in synthetic media. Chun

explains that this epistemology depends on an illusion of privacy that the internet creates, going back to the blurring of boundaries between the public and private (151). The digital realm promises individuals the ability to curate and control their image, but simultaneously makes them vulnerable to forms of exposure they cannot anticipate or manage. This leads to comments that blame the victims for this outing, as they are shamed for not having been completely exposed to begin with. Deepfakes capitalize on this paradox, weaponizing the very infrastructure that enables visibility and self-expression. This is how the epistemology of outing allows us to understand deepfakes not simply as isolated incidents of harm but as a systematic cycle of violence. The act of "outing" a persona through deepfake technology mimics traditional forms of violence that render marginalized bodies legible only through violation.

Further harm is inflicted through the relentless demand for verification. Many of the user's within these comments demand to see the video in order to determine its authenticity, turning the spectators into participants in the violation. Even those who appear sympathetic only do so on the condition of access. As one user tweets, "ain't look AI to me… y'all know she be lying… 🌝" (@mermiee), casting doubt on the claim and implying that only visual proof will suffice. This desire to reaffirm Megan Thee Stallion as a sexual being, either by denying her trauma or demanding proof of it, reflects on internet users' deeper need to impose legibility through violation. The comments make it clear that users feel they can only validate this violation if they gain more information about the legitimacy of the violation, forcing Megan Thee Stallion to make it legible to them. For instance, one commenter writes, "This b!tch can't even own up to her trash sextape😂" (@hewontmiss123), mocking her and demanding an admission, as if her

silence or resistance to engagement delegitimizes her position. The public commentary becomes a spectacle of its own, where the persona is re-violated through hyper-visibility, judgment, and invasive speculations. We see this in the court documents surrounding these leaked deepfakes, where Megan Thee Stallion's past relationship and accusation of Tory Lanez are brought up and dissected.

Conclusion

Through the analysis of this case, I've provided an analysis of pornographic deepfake dissemination as a new phenomenon that intensifies and expands digital sexual violence. The technology we now have means that, similar to Noelle Martin's quick Google search of your name, it could lead you to pornographic websites with videos and images that are completely fabricated. But as we've seen with Benjamin and Chun, this structure of exploitation is not new. The inherent nature of the internet has always been about outing and exposure in a way that encourages users to shame those who have been exposed while still craving more of their intimate information. The comment sections to news outlets that reported on Megan Thee Stallion's deepfake show how entitlement is exacerbated by anonymity and the clustering algorithm. We see how this entitlement can also stem from parasocial relationships users may have with Megan Thee Stallion, and how this could feed their sense of entitlement. This entitlement leads to the cyclical violence of demanding justification and, in doing so, re-violating Megan Thee Stallion. This thesis is not to encourage technopessimism but rather to encourage users to come to terms with the possibilities this new technology introduces. Urging users to take a more critical stance when it comes to the use of these new and improved machine learning and

AI technologies. I urge you to think about how the misuse of these technologies can further discriminate against minority groups.

As a Computer Science major, one of my biggest dilemmas was that as we were being taught about these complex new technologies, we were often never prompted to think critically about the effects of this technology. Though AI ethics was discussed in both my Artificial Intelligence and Deep Learning classes, it often felt like an afterthought, something simply added to the end of a syllabi and often skipped for the sake of exploring ‘more important’ technical components. This thesis feels like an embodiment of these concerns where the intention is not to discourage users from inhabiting digital spaces or to suggest developers should no longer create new technology. Rather, I encourage both users and developers to create a more holistic understanding of these tools. I urge both users and developers to engage critically, ethically, and empathetically with the technologies they use and build.

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